

Si-ings

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Baseball Could, but Won't, Move in on Wives-Lives Swap

TAMPA—MONDAY MUSINGS (Florida Division) . . .
Angry question in my mail regarding the Kekich-Peterson swap of wives and lives: "Why doesn't baseball take strong action against these bums for violating moral laws?"



Peterson

Baseball could, if it wanted to, by calling on the "Loyalty" clause in what is known as the "Uniform Players' Contract." . . . I have a copy of the contract of which Clause 3. (a) reads: "The player agrees to perform his services hereunder diligently and faithfully, to keep himself in first-class physical condition and to obey the club's training rules, and PLEDGES HIMSELF TO THE AMERICAN PUBLIC AND TO THE CLUB TO CONFORM TO HIGH STANDARDS OF PERSONAL CONDUCT (the capital letters are mine), fair play and good sportsmanship" . . .

Up to maybe five years ago, the embarrassed Yankees, league presidents or commissioners might have thrown the book at any offenders . . . But considering the new mores, you can bet that it simply would not stand up in today's courts . . .

Such a ruling also might alienate the upper-teens and young adults, who've been patronizing the game in recent years . . . That doesn't excuse it, but that's how it is . . .

Anti-libel suggestion: When Kekich or Peterson warms up in the Yankee bullpen, don't make the mistake of calling either one "loose" . . .

—Reactions

Dozens of gags on the wives-lives trade are bouncing around Florida. One of the goodies is Ohio State alumnus Jim Campbell's . . . The general manager of the Tigers suggests he'll insist on knowing the Yankee pitching assignment in advance so he can advertise the games as PG or X-rated . . .

Not all the original details of the deal have stood up . . . Mrs. Kekich has joined Mr. Peterson, but Mrs. Peterson has reneged on the bargain, leaving Mike in left field, which is no place, of course, for a pitcher . . .

Also, the kids aren't being swapped; all now stay with their own mothers . . . That probably means the dog trade is off, too . . . The Petersons originally were to give up their Scotch terrier for the Kekiches' poodle . . .

Most naive approach to the deal: The surprise registered by Yankee officials that the media would make so much of the situation . . . What did they expect, polite silence? . . . Then there's the big league writer whose newspaper has asked him to probe the private lives of all the players on the club he covers . . . Sorry, I would consider this an invasion of privacy, theirs and mine . . .

—Morgan Analysis

On more prosaic subjects, listen to Joe Morgan's beautiful line about the Reds: "To me, there's no way to get closer than we are on this club. In my winter speeches I always say if society was like our team, we'd have very few problems" . . . Which removes all corniness from the "togetherness" theme.

Roberta Albers, daughter of former Daytonian Tom, long a top notch amateur golfer in the Tampa area, makes her pro debut this weekend in the Orange Blossom classic at St. Petersburg, a \$25,000 LPGA event . . . Carol Mann defends . . .

Oakwood high graduate Bob Rickey, visiting in these parts on a golf-oriented business trip connected with his duties as a MacGregor veep, talked about tennis: "The game is growing so fast it's exploding. TV helped golf, and now it's helping tennis. Tennis helps itself by being better exercise, less time-consuming, less expensive and more available" . . .

Darrel Chaney, the Reds' infielder, spent the winter as an assistant golf pro in Tallahassee, where his ex-Cincy room-mate, Woody Woodward, is executive veep of a huge land-development firm . . .

"Woody's doing well," Darrel reports. "He didn't even regret retiring last year, although it cost him a World Series share, because his firm gave him a \$13,000 Christmas bonus . . . Chaney on his own golf game: "I shoot in the upper 70's. If it gets any warmer, I don't go out" . . .

—Tanner Lauds Andy Cohen

Mickey McConnell, one-time business manager of the old Dayton Mid-Atlantic league team, is in Florida visiting big league camps in his capacity as national Director of Training for the Little Leagues . . . When Mickey ran the office, Andy Cohen managed the Dayton club and they were known then as an "Abe's Irish Rose" combo . . .

Anyway, Mickey told about attending a session of the NCAA Baseball Coaches' convention in January . . . He was listening to Chuck Tanner, Chicago White Sox manager, make a talk to the group . . . Tanner told about the man who made the greatest contribution to his career . . .

"Andy Cohen managed me first at Wassau, Wis., and then at Denver. What he taught me was a priceless contribution to my career" . . .

"In the middle of his talk, Cohen wandered into the room," McConnell recalled . . . "He tried to sneak out when he realized Tanner was talking about him, but his colleagues made him move to the front of the room. Andy, you know, coaches baseball at U. of Texas-El Paso. That tribute must have been a thrill to him, but it gave me just as great a charge," McConnell said . . .